

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

Property tax hike 'likely' in 2026

Johnson to revisit plan to close city's \$1B budget deficit

By A.D. Quig and Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

Mayor Brandon Johnson's team teased plans this week to take another swing at raising property taxes to close the city's more than \$1 billion budget gap, despite an aldermanic revolt last year and continued resistance to such a hike.

Asked in an interview with Bloomberg's Romaine Bostick whether a property tax increase would again be proposed for the city's 2026 budget, Chief Financial Officer Jill Jaworski said "it is likely that that will be part of the package," without addressing how to garner support from the City Council to pass it.

Johnson's team on Wednesday emphasized the budget was not yet finalized and that the mayor "is focused on identifying progressive revenue opportunities that ensure that the ultra-wealthy pay their fair share and that this budget is not balanced on the backs of working people."

One of Johnson's "budget-teers" last year, Ald. Matt O'Shea, 19th, said he would need to see major cuts and efficiencies to be won over.

"And if it doesn't happen, I'm a no vote, and so are the majority of my colleagues," he said of a potential property tax hike. "We need to start talking about stuff we never talked about before."

Jaworski affirmed cuts will also be part of the mayor's budget package, but said the administration is "hoping to avoid" reducing services.

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CHICAGO PUBLIC SCHOOLS

'No cuts are going to be good cuts'

Parents, community frustrated with CPS budget deficit woes

By Kate Perez
Chicago Tribune

Sitting in the packed and tense cafeteria at George Westinghouse College Prep School in Humboldt Park, Marquis Griffin did not envision himself having to be at the school on a Tuesday night in July, his children in tow and anxious to run around.

But a lot is at stake for Griffin, his two sons and their mother if Chicago Public Schools fails to minimize its \$734 million budget deficit. His boys, Marquis Jr., 7, and Myles, 5, who live with autism, risk losing the services the district provides for students with disabilities, including the specialized aides who may not be there come fall. The boys' mother, DeAndrea Davis, is a special education classroom assistant, or SECA, who has seen her colleagues recently lose their jobs.

Griffin, Davis and their sons attended one of several forums CPS hosted at high schools around the city in recent weeks to hear stakeholders' ideas on how to solve the deficit. The district must have a balanced budget by Aug. 28 — 11 days after the school year begins

Turn to CPS, Page 4



Francisco Guerrero, left, and Tania Navarrete, both former Gompers Park encampment residents, watch Navarrete's cat, Tinkerbell, as she plays in her new apartment Friday in Chicago. AUDREY RICHARDSON/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

\$40M upgrade ahead for homeless shelters

Mayor touts 'healthier, safer and more private' facilities spanning all Chicago

By Rebecca Johnson
Chicago Tribune

Tania Navarrete welcomes a group of city employees to her new apartment on the South Side. She guides them through the living room and bedroom and then into her kitchen. Art lines the walls and the fridge is fully stocked with food.

The employees, on a "special assignment" for the day, are with the city's Homeless Outreach and Prevention team. They helped Navarrete find and move into the new apartment about a month ago. The 33-year-old had lived

for about three years inside a tent at the contentious Gompers Park homeless encampment after being evicted from her apartment.

"It's so comfortable here compared to the park," Navarrete told the Tribune. "So much problems over there. I better stay here."

The group of four employees made a quick stop at Navarrete's apartment last week to check in and bring her supplies, including food, bedding and a new toy for her black cat, Tinkerbell, a stray that Navarrete picked up at Gompers. The team spends their days building trust with many of

the more than 7,000 people across the city experiencing homelessness. The goal is to help them rebuild and improve their lives.

Navarrete is a success story, a bright spot in a system plagued with inequities and community pushback. But success stories take time and require resources, Luis Santiago, a community intervention specialist said. And there's two resources he said he's lacking most in his job — affordable units, particularly on the Northwest Side, and quality shelter space. The city combined its migrant and homeless shelters, called the "One System Initia-

tive," to mixed success.

"Shelter space is so tight right now because of One System," Santiago said. "We just need more shelter, and that takes funding."

In a step toward that goal, Mayor Brandon Johnson and the Department of Family & Support Services announced Wednesday a \$40 million investment to "modernize" homeless shelters throughout the city, calling it the "largest local shelter capital investment in Chicago's history."

Seven shelters received provisional grants, according to DFSS.

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ANTONIO PEREZ/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Cooler heads prevailing

Thursday	Friday	Saturday
High 94 Low 73	High 82 Low 71	High 85 Low 72

A person sits under an umbrella at Margaret T. Burroughs Beach on Chicago's South Side on Wednesday. The National Weather Service has placed a heat advisory in effect until 10 p.m. Thursday. A cold front is expected to arrive at the end of the week, which could aid in creating conditions for storms. **Chicagoland forecast, Page 16**

NASCAR's California dream

With Chicago on hold, NASCAR announced Wednesday that it is headed to San Diego next summer to host a new street race weekend on an active naval base. The three-day event, dubbed the NASCAR San Diego Weekend, will take place in June 2026, filling the void on the schedule left by the Chicago race. **Business**

Epstein request rejected

A judge Wednesday rejected a request to unseal transcripts from grand jury investigations of Jeffrey Epstein. Meanwhile, a new report said President Donald Trump was told that he's mentioned "multiple times" in the Justice Department's files related the investigation of Epstein. **Nation & World in Business, Page 6**

WORTH TOWNSHIP

Ex-official skirts prison in red-light camera case

By Jason Meisner
Chicago Tribune

A former south suburban official was sentenced to 18 months of probation Wednesday for his role in a scheme to pay bribes to get lucrative red-light cameras installed in Oak Lawn.

In sentencing John O'Sullivan, 57, a onetime Worth Township supervisor and state lawmaker, U.S. District Judge LaShonda Hunt said even low-level corruption erodes the public's faith in government and leads to the assumption that "we act in our own self-interests, not in the interest of constituents."

"This pay-to-play mentality really does have to end," Hunt said. "This is your community, Mr. O'Sullivan. ... The point was to get additional red-light cameras approved in your

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\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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